

fridayReview

THE HINDU

The widening repertoire
Kalakshetra's three-day Kathakali festival highlighted new narratives **p2**

Spotlight on male dancers
'Bhavesu Nayakah' offered a platform to four young performers **p2**



STORY OF THE GHAZAL QUEEN

A dastangoi performance traced the life and music of Begum Akhtar **p3**

In his birth centenary year, a look at how the legendary lyricist brought philosophy, classical Tamil literature and the realities of everyday life to the common man in simple language

People's

Bala Shankar

There are songs we return to time and again, drawn in by their melodies or lyrics. Sometimes, a single line can capture an emotion so perfectly that it lingers long after the music ends. Years later, we may still remember it, finding new meaning in it as life changes. This is the enduring power of a lyricist's words.

Between 1950 and 1981 emerged one such colossal poet and writer whose works continue to be analysed, cherished, quoted and celebrated. Kannadasan penned more than 5,000 film songs, and an equal number of poems, wrote screenplays for more than a dozen films, authored over 200 books, and edited several Tamil magazines. Yet, his significant contribution to modern Tamil literature and public discourse, cannot be measured by statistics alone. There is now a flourishing cultural industry built around Kannadasan and his works - with speeches, competitions, debates and book commentaries, keeping his words alive for successive generations.

Born in a small village of Sirukoodalpatti near Karaikudi, Muthiah was the eighth child of a family that had fallen on difficult times. His formal education stopped after the eighth grade. Yet, lack of schooling was not a barrier when he moved to Chennai seeking writing opportunities. His love for Tamil was nurtured

by his mother's lullabies. He rechristened himself as Kannadasan before one of his early breakthroughs in films. By the time he turned 30, Kannadasan became renowned in his field.

His lyrics brought out vital emotions, philosophical ideas, relationship conundrums and worldly matters through succinct and impactful phrases. With just 10-lines in a film song, he could move effortlessly from happiness to sorrow, love and intimacy to questions of morality and existence, often using a language that was both sensitive and accessible. The lyrics of 'Mayakkama kalakkama' (*Sumai Thangi*) can lift a desperate mind towards hope, while 'Manithan enbavan deivamagalam' from the same film extols the virtues of those who do societal good. 'Ninaippathellam nadanthu vittal' from *Nenjil Oar Alayam* reminds us that there is a higher force that guides our lives, and 'Aru maname aru' from *Andavan Kattalai*, prescribes a code of conduct. These are merely a few examples of Kannadasan's extraordinary ability to weave philosophy into cinematic narratives.

Kannadasan was known to pack an entire story into a song - much like a ballad. 'Malargalai pol thangai' from the epochal drama, *Pasamalar*, and 'Ore oru oorile' from *Padikkatha Medhai* are inimitable examples. His ability to write lyrics instantly to a tune gave the impression that words came to him effortlessly. Brevity and simplicity were the

hallmarks of his writing. He also possessed the rare skill to express expansive ideas in a few concise lines without diluting their impact.

Kannadasan's encapsulation of the core elements of the *Bhagavad Gita*, which runs into 18 chapters and 700 verses, in 18 lines in 'Ullathil nalla ullam' (*Karnan*) deserves a special place in the world of literature. In fact, he bequeathed a whole new genre of simple Tamil poetry that could convey profound ideas.

Between 1950 and 1981, Kannadasan wrote over 5,000 film songs, thousands of poems, and more than 200 books. Yet his legacy lies not in statistics but in the way he compressed vast emotions and philosophical ideas into memorable lines that continue to resonate across generations.

ILLUSTRATION:
SOUMYADIP SINHA

Kannadasan's spiritual journey is equally interesting. As a young man, he spent most of his time in his village's Malai Arasi temple. His early political allegiances subsequently led him towards atheism. But he soon became a believer again and went on to write the 10-volume magnum opus *Arthamulla Indhu matham* (Meaningful Hindu Religion), which has so far sold a million copies and continues to be reprinted.

Many of Kannadasan's film

songs include cryptic lines from ancient texts such as *Kamba Ramayanam*, *Periyapuranam* and *Silappadikaram*. They showed his deep understanding of these works. In one song, he wrote, 'Pesa maranthu silayaai ninral athu than deivathin sannidhi', the line bore resemblance to *Kamba Ramayanam*'s verse on Rama and Sita meeting each other for the first time. The song 'Thol kanden thole kanden' (*Idhaya Kamalam*) is another pick from *Kamba Ramayanam*.

Similarly, 'Sivalingam satchi sonna kadaiyum poyyo' in a song from the film *Tiruvilaiyadal* refers to Shiva appearing as a witness to save a woman from her suspicious husband. The song, 'Attuvithal yaaroruvur aadathare' leans on Appar's Tevaram hymn with the same starting words.

He is said to have written songs based on interesting wordplay, particularly alliterations, wherever he found them, even on scraps of paper. 'Atthan ennathan' (*Pava Mannippu*) and 'Atthikkai kai kai' (*Bale Pandya*) best illustrate this.

Kannadasan established a remarkable creative partnership with music composer M.S. Viswanathan. Together, they created songs that have become immortal in Tamil cinema. Their professional and personal bond lasted for over two decades until Kannadasan's untimely death in 1981.

Writing took Kannadasan to politics, film-making and philanthropy. He did not quiet succeed in the first two ventures. He had once remarked that "he earned like a king but borrowed like a nation". His years in the celluloid world, exposed him to deception, envy, ill-will, betrayal and ingratitude. Yet, he retained a moral compass that kept him out of all these.

In his autobiographical account in *Vanavasam*, written in the third person, Kannadasan indulges in self-criticism and opens up on his personal life and vulnerabilities. He mentions being married more than once and having 15 children.

This honesty may be the reason why his lyrics have transcended their time and continue to connect with the same felicity across social and intellectual stratas - scholars and commoners, believers and sceptics, and the young and old.

CULTUREBRIEFS

Musical ode to Sivan

Papanasam Sivan Rasikar Sangam, in association with Narada Gana Sabha, will present the Sivanisai Music Festival to commemorate the 136th birth anniversary of the legendary composer. It will be held from September 26 to 30 at Sathguru Gnanananda Hall. Papanasam Sivan's 53rd memorial day will be observed on October 1, at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore. The event is a musical ode to the composer, who enriched the Carnatic repertoire and also wrote songs for Tamil cinema.

He developed a passion for composing songs after moving from Kerala to Tamil Nadu. In 1910, he travelled to Papanasam to stay with his brother. It is there that he began to listen to Carnatic concerts, which motivated him to pen kritis. The



legendary vocalist Konerirajapuram Vaidyanatha Iyer, whose concerts Sivan would listen to the most, also inspired him to compose songs.

When Sivan settled in Madras in 1929, Rukmini Devi was among the first to recognise his genius. He was associated with Kalakshetra from 1934 to 1939, during which time Rukmini Devi was one of his students. Perhaps his tenure at Kalakshetra prompted him to compose several pada varnams that are now performed in Bharatanatyam.

He would lead the early morning processions through Mylapore's *mada veedhis* during Margazhi.

Even after his passing, the tradition has been carried on by musicians.

One of Sivan's earliest songs on Lord Kapaleeswarar, 'Kaana Kankodi' in Kamboji, was composed during one of these outings.

His kriti, 'Srirama nama bhajanaisai maname', reflects his devotion to Rama. Since his original name was Ramayya, he also used it as the mudra in his kritis.

Strings eternal

The Music Academy will feature the violin concert of H.K. Venkatram and B.U. Ganesh Prasad on September 28, 6 p.m. at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. They will be accompanied by Neyveli S. Skandasubramaniam on the mridangam and Adambakkam K. Sankar on the ghatam. The programme is organised under the Lalgudi G. Jayaraman memorial endowment, instituted by Lalgudi G.J.R. Krishnan and Lalgudi Vijayalakshmi, and is supported by KVB CSR initiative.

Bharathanjali's next



him. Choreography is by Anitha Guha and music is composed by Rajkumar Bharathi and Soundscape design by Sai Shravanam. Tickets are available at www.tikkl.com/desikadaya



Suganthi Krishnamachari

Theatre Marina presented a collection of seven standalone short plays at KGS Arena, Krishna Gana Sabha's initiative to showcase performances beyond the realm of classical arts.

Anthology theatre demands flawless curation. Even when the plays lack a common thematic thread, a single weak narrative can act like a card pulled from a carefully-balanced pyramid, bringing the entire edifice crashing down. Fortunately, R. Giridharan's curation and direction ensured an evening of theatre rooted in humour.

In *Chithappa Vijayam* a letter sets off a flurry of activity in the protagonist's household, because an uncle he has never seen is going to arrive for a short stay. But, does the uncle arrive? That is the twist in the play.

Shifting gears, the second play, *Coffee with Kadavul*, had a more serious theme. Raghunathan, a 59-year-old bachelor, had resolved long ago to marry only after completing his Chartered Accountancy – a milestone that continues to elude him. The premise resonated with the audience, capturing the all-too-familiar anxiety surrounding the notoriously low success rates of CA exams. The narrative illustrated the cruel irony of fate; which often grants us our lifelong desires only when it is too late for us to enjoy them.

Avan Aval Adhu was about two theatre buffs – one eager to be on stage, while the other keen to watch plays. To indulge their passions, they concoct excuses at their work place, each dreading the other might reveal the secret to the manager.

Rail Sneham revolved around Govindasamy, who pours his heart out in a letter to his neighbour Ramasamy, listing all his complaints against the latter's family; yet insists he wants to be a good neighbour. The punchline lands when he reveals he is mailing the letter from Mumbai after having heard that the latter's kitchen is on fire. But the letter arrives too late, leaving the audience looking at Ramasamy and his wife with burn injuries.

Ulagu Vazhakkam, the best play in the collection (written by J. Raghunathan), was a



Short and sweet (From above) Scenes from *Chithappa Vijayam*; *Ulagu Vazhakkam*; and *Marakkuma Nenjam*. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

masterpiece in human psychology. It dissected the allure of wealth and the ways in which sibling envy determines life choices and also showed how a clever father (Kamaraj Mani) manipulates his daughter into accepting a bridegroom of his choice. The playwright balanced emotional depth with a tongue-in-cheek tone within a brief runtime, thereby showcasing his writing skills.

Malayankulathu Ninaivugal was about two characters reminiscing about life in their ancestral village. Just as one was wondering what the play offered beyond a string of recollections, the writer delivered his surprise ending.

Marakkuma Nenjam was about a reunion of three old friends. But, there is no deep dive into the past, as the three elderly women suffer from memory loss. Conversation gets stuck in loops about sugarless coffee, with the women sipping endless cups without even realising it. Actors Anitha Balachander, Vidhyalakshmi and Latha made these characters thoroughly endearing.

Playwrights often run a single theme to death and still feel they haven't said enough. These short plays served as a reminder that stagecraft can be brief yet remarkably effective.

Ode to a songstress (Clockwise from right) Begum Akhtar; Yusra Naqvi with Gaurav Gadiyar (harmonium) and Kedarnath Havaladar (tabla); and Kafeel Jafri. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & K. MURALI KUMAR



enabled her not just manage the trip but to return with some money. I feel she was someone who went with the flow," believes the dastango.

Yusra's rendition – of ghazals, thumris and dadras – doesn't interrupt the story but rather acts like extensions of it. For Begum Akhtar's first heartbreak, Kafeel chose 'Muhabbat tere anjaam pe rona aaya', to reflect on her relationship with the Nawab of Gaya and her pain on discovering that he had been unfaithful. Other familiar songs sit alongside the less-frequently heard pieces such as 'Koyalia mat pukaar' or 'Dil ki baat kahi nahin jaati chupke rahna thana hai' by Mir Taqi Mir.

Yusra has her own long relationship with one of the pieces in the performance. She first learnt 'Chha rahi kaari ghata, jiya mora lehrae hai', a dadra, when she was 11. Her father, an admirer of Begum Akhtar, had introduced her to it. "But I was too naive to understand the depth of her music," she says. One can learn the words and melodies, but the emotional depth of her music is tough to grasp.

In Begum Akhtar's life the classical and the popular, and the personal and the public were clearly divided. She flitted in and out of these worlds, sometimes with ease and at times at a considerable cost. What Dastan-e-Akhtari does, is to allow all those versions of her to come together. Kafeel Jafri now plans to take this work to Pune then to Mumbai, and Kolkata.

Of heartbreaks and high notes

How a recent Dastangoi performance journeyed into the world of Begum Akhtar

Shailaja Tripathi

In the aesthetic setting of Sabhablr, on a recent evening in Bengaluru, Kafeel Jafri sat down to tell the life story of a woman, whose journey was nothing short of extraordinary. Known as the Mallika-e-Ghazal, Begum Akhtar navigated the path of social marginalisation to become one of the most celebrated voices of the country. Her life was marked by love, heartbreak, fame, friendship, loneliness and rebellion. Amidst all this, music remained her steadfast companion.

Kafeel unfolded the story through the tradition of Dastangoi, a centuries-old art form of storytelling that relies on voice, imagination, and direct interaction between the storyteller and the audience. 'Dastan' means story and 'goi' means telling. Originating in Persia, the form went extinct by the early 20th century before being revived in a contemporary form. What

makes it particularly suited to a life such as Begum Akhtar's is its fluidity. It allows the dastango to juggle narration, dialogue, humour and song.

Dastan-e-Akhtari embodies this tradition. Kafeel's narration, interspersed with songs sung by Yusra Naqvi, gives Begum Akhtar's music another dimension. They were accompanied by live tabla, harmonium, and sarangi.

The story begins with Begum Akhtar's mother, Mushtari Bai, who was married into a family in Lucknow, but was not accepted by her in-laws, and was eventually disowned by them. Her daughter, Akhtari, was born into a world in which questions of respectability, money and a woman's place in society were commonplace. Through the piece, Kafeel explores how these experiences shaped the daughter's life. Rather than presenting Begum Akhtar as a tragic persona, he seeks to understand the choices she made and the circumstances in which they

were made. Kafeel says he wanted to look closely at the stories about the musician, especially the question of her agency.

For instance, Begum Akhtar's decision to stop singing after marriage is often perceived as she was forced into giving up music. Kafeel views it differently. "Social pressure certainly played a role, but she also made an active choice because marriage offered her the respectability that her background had denied her," he says. She regretted it, and missed singing, but to describe her only as a woman without a choice, he reasons, is to simplify her life.

Kafeel grew up listening to Begum Akhtar's music. There was another personal connection: he was born in

Known as Mallika-e-Ghazal, Begum Akhtar navigated the path of social marginalisation to become one of the most celebrated voices of the country.

CALENDAR

Thematic performance

As part of the 13th anniversary celebrations of **Sankara Natyalaya**, a thematic production 'Theenduveerayin Emmai Tiruneelakandam', choreographed by dancer Kanaka Krishna Prashanth, will be presented on October 2, 5.30 p.m. at Karnatak Sangha Auditorium, T. Nagar. It is based on the life of the Saivite saint Tiruneelakanda Nayanar. K.N. Ramaswamy, director, Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Chennai Kendra, and N. Kamakoti, former CEO and Managing director of City Union Bank, are the chief guests.

Award for senior musician

Hamsadhwani will honour senior musician Malladi Suribabu with the 'Sathguru Thyagaraja Hamsadhwani Award' at a special event, to be held on September 26, 6.05 p.m., at Youth Hostel, Adyar. This will be followed by his vocal concert. Malladi Sree Rama Prasad and Malladi Ravi Kumar will lend vocal support. They will be accompanied by Malladi Sindhu Rageswari on the violin, Malladi Aravind Karthik and Malladi Sivanand Yasasvi on the double mridangam.

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Debut

Prajwalita Rao, disciple of Anuradha Vikranth, will perform her Bharatanatyam rangapravesha on September 26, 6 p.m. at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Bengaluru.

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Future-Proofing Your Fertility?

In recent years, social egg freezing has transitioned from a niche medical procedure into an essential option for many women. Today's generation faces a dynamic set of life choices and circumstances that often lead to delaying pregnancy and marriage. Women are increasingly prioritising higher education, pursuing demanding career goals, or simply taking time to find the right partner. Additionally, life shifts such as late marriage or divorce may mean that many women find themselves ready to start a family much later. Regardless, egg freezing serves as a reliable option, allowing women to preserve their fertility choices without completely compromising their current life goals.

The single most critical factor determining success. The ideal age window to freeze eggs is between 25 and 32 years. During this period, a woman's reproductive system typically produces eggs of optimal genetic quality and in higher quantities. If a woman in this age bracket knows she intends to postpone pregnancy, consulting a fertility specialist during these years provides the best statistical chance of achieving a healthy, successful pregnancy in the future.

While the mid-twenties to early thirties represent the primary window, women frequently consider egg freezing later in life. It is important to understand how biological timing affects outcomes:

The Sweet Spot for Quality and Quantity
When considering egg freezing,

age is the single most critical factor determining success. The ideal age window to freeze eggs is between 25 and 32 years. During this period, a woman's reproductive system typically produces eggs of optimal genetic quality and in higher quantities. If a woman in this age bracket knows she intends to postpone pregnancy, consulting a fertility specialist during these years provides the best statistical chance of achieving a healthy, successful pregnancy in the future.

While the mid-twenties to early thirties represent the primary window, women frequently consider egg freezing later in life. It is important to understand how biological timing affects outcomes:

The Age 32-33 Shift: Around 32 to 33 years of age, women typically begin to experience a natural decline

Dr. K.S. Kavitha Gautham, MBBS, MS (OG)
Managing Director, BloomLife Hospital Pvt. Ltd.

in both the overall egg count (ovarian reserve) and the genetic quality of those eggs.

Egg Freezing Beyond Age 35: Egg freezing is still entirely possible after age 35, and many women pursue it successfully. However, because older eggs have a slightly higher rate of chromosomal variations, a woman may need more stimulation cycles to freeze a sufficient number of healthy eggs, and the overall statistical likelihood of a future successful pregnancy is somewhat lower compared to freezing at a younger age.

Taking proactive steps early ensures that when the time is right for you to start a family, you have the highest quality options available.

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Papanasam Sivan Rasikar Sangam, Chennai
in association with

Narada Gana Sabha, Chennai
presents

Sivanisai Music Festival - 2026
on the occasion of
**136th Birthday Celebrations of
Brahmasri Papanasam Sivan**

September 26, 2026 - September 30, 2026
at Sathguru Gnanananda Hall, Narada Gana Sabha, T.T.K. Road, Chennai - 18

October 1, 2026
Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore, Chennai - 4



PROGRAMME

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 26, 2026

3:00 PM : Grand Inaugural Concert
Vid. Raghul Vellal - Vocal
Vid. Siva Teja - Violin
Vid. Kishore Ramesh - Mridangam
Vid. Madipakkam Murali - Ghatam

5:00 PM : Sri Kapaleeswarar Pancharatnam
A Tribute to Sri. Papanasam Sivan
Group Rendition by Vidwans and Vidhushis

**6:00 PM : Anugraha Bhashanam
by HH “Sri Sankara Vijayendra Saraswathi Swamigal”**

Grand Inauguration & Presentation of Prizes
To the Winners of Papanasam Sivan Competitions
Including Tambura Prize
Instituted in memory of Smt. Narayaniammal Vaidyasubramania Iyer

Chief Guest
Sri. Aneish Rajan, Director, Ministry of Culture, Govt. of India,
New Delhi

Guest of Honour
Cleveland Sri. V.V. Sundaram, Co-Founder, Cleveland Thyagaraja
Aradhana Festival

7:15 PM : Andal Charitham
Dance Drama Production composed by Sri Papanasam Sivan
and presented by Kalakshetra Foundation

SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 27, 2026

4:00 PM : Thillai Thaandavarayan
Thematic Presentation of Compositions of Sri. Papanasam Sivan on
Thillai by "Hamsanadam Music School" of Dr. Shubha Ganesan

5:00 PM : Sampradhaya Kutcheri
Vid. Ramakrishnan Murthy - Vocal
Vid. L. Ramakrishnan - Violin
Vid. Trivandrum Balaji - Mridangam

7:00 PM : Sivan Vazhiyil Cinema - QFR Live
Presented by Subhasree Thanikachalam
Vid. Santhosh Subramanian - Vocal
Vid. Rishipriya Guruprasath - Vocal
Vid. Vigneshwar V.G. - Keys
Vid. Durai Srinivasan - Violin
Vid. Shri Hari - Tabla & Mridangam
Vid. Harishma - Percussion Support

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 28, 2026

5:00 PM : Melodies of Sri Papanasam Sivan
Vid. Bharat Sundar - Vocal
Vid. Rajeev Mukundan - Violin
Vid. Anirudh Raj - Mridangam
Vid. K.V. Gopalakrishnan - Kanjira

7:00 PM : Film Hits of Sri Papanasam Sivan
Vid. Rajhesh Vaidhya - Veena
Vid. Bharath - Keyboard
Vid. Manikandan - Keyboard
Vid. Sathish - Flute
Vid. Mohanaraman - Mridangam
Vid. Ganapathi - Tabla
Vid. Subramanian - Timing

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

5:00 PM : Carnatic Jugalbandi
Vid. Kunnakudi M. Balamuralikrishna - Vocal
Vid. M.A. Sundaresan - Violin
Vid. Mylai Karthikeyan - Nadaswaram
Vid. Mannargudi M.R. Vasudevan &
Vid. Tharapuram V Ganesan - Special Thavil

7:00 PM : Sivanin Paadhayil - Sangeetha Upanyasam
Sri. U.Ve. Dushyanth Sridhar
Vocal Support by Vid. Sakthi Muralidharan

WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

5:00 PM : Gems of Sri Papanasam Sivan
Vid. Ashwath Narayanan - Vocal
Vid. S. Varadarajan - Violin
Vid. J. Vaidyanathan - Mridangam
Vid. N. Guruprasad - Ghatam

7:00 PM : Bhakthi Isai Concert
Vid. Gayathri Venkataraghavan
Vid. Mysore V. Srikanth - Violin
Vid. Neyveli R. Narayanan - Mridangam
Vid. K.V. Gopalakrishnan - Kanjira

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 1, 2026
at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan,
Mylapore, Chennai - 4

**Sri. Papanasam Sivan’s 53rd Memorial Day
in association with
Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Chennai**

Chief Guest
Thiru. P. Venkataramanan,
Hon’ble Minister For Food and Civil Supplies,
Government of Tamil Nadu

Guests of Honour
Thiru. K.N. Ramaswamy, Director, Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan,
Chennai Kendra
Thiru. R.V. Shekar, Managing Director, Lancor Holdings
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**5:45 PM : “Sivanisai Selvar” Award
to Vid. Sikkil Gurucharan**
Followed by
Vid. Sikkil Gurucharan - Vocal
Vid. L. Ramakrishnan - Violin
Vid. B. Sivaraman - Mridangam
Vid. S. Krishna - Ghatam

Master of Ceremonies: Smt. Revathy Sankaran

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